

Dvar Torah Outline — Rosh Hashanah's Three Books: Rashi, Maharal, and Reframing “Life and Death”

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman analyzes a well-known but difficult Gemara (Rosh Hashanah 16b) about three “books” opened on Rosh Hashanah—of רשעים, צדיקים, and בינוניים—and challenges the common assumption that it refers simply to who will physically live or die that year. Following Rashi, he reframes the books as “books of remembrance” of one’s deeds, and—using the Maharal—redefines “life” as connection to Hashem and “death” as disconnection. The dvar Torah culminates in a practical roadmap: how mundane, “in-between” actions can be elevated through כוונה and rededication during עשרת ימי תשובה so that they too are “written for life.”

I. The Gemara in Rosh Hashanah: three books and the basic difficulty

A. The source text and its categories

- Gemara (Rosh Hashanah 16b): three books open on Rosh Hashanah:
 - one for צדיקים גמורים
 - one for רשעים גמורים
 - one for בינוניים
- Outcome described:
 - written and sealed immediately: לחיים צדיקים
 - written and sealed immediately: למיתה רשעים
 - : לחיים, if not → למיתה until Yom Kippur; if they merit → ועומדים בינוניים:

B. Rabbi Shulman surfaces multiple conceptual questions

- What does “merit” mean practically for the בינוני between Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur?
- Why is the דין presented as binary (life/death) for the בינוני?
 - Why can’t a person simply remain “in the middle” if nothing changes?
- Who is actually a בינוני?
 - Is it 50/50 מצוות vs עבירות (seems unlikely), or is almost everyone a בינוני (also strange)?

C. A structural question: what happens to the “book of בינוניים”?

- If in the end people are written for life or death, what becomes of the middle book?
 - The Gemara’s language implies:
 - “are “written and sealed צדיקים/רשעים
 - “are not “written” immediately, only “suspended בינוניים
 - Rabbi Shulman highlights the oddity: it seems like the middle book functions like a “prop” unless we rethink what the books are.
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II. Rashi’s five-word shift: the books are “books of deeds,” not lists of names (7:30)

A. Rashi’s redefinition

- Rashi: “ספרי זכרון של מעשי הבריות”
 - (Books of remembrance recording the deeds of people)

B. Clarifying “ספר זכרון” through a familiar model

- Rabbi Shulman compares it to Achashverosh’s royal chronicle in the Purim story:
 - a running record of events that can later be opened and reviewed.
- Implication:
 - On Rosh Hashanah, what is “opened” is the record of actions and their spiritual reality—not merely a verdict list.

C. Support from Pirkei Avot (and the Meiri’s linkage)

- Mishnah (Avot 2): “וכל מעשיך בספר נכתבים” (and all your deeds are written in a book).
 - The “book” is an account of deeds, reinforcing Rashi’s approach.
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III. Maharal in Avot: why “a book” helps prevent sin—no harm is never “no foul” (10:00)

A. The core psychological problem with many עבירות

- People easily avoid visible harm (hurting, breaking, damaging) because consequences are obvious.

- But in עבירות like חילול שבת, non-kosher, לשון הרע:
 - the damage is not visible, so one feels “I got away with it.”

B. The Maharal's concept of the “book”

- The “book” is the spiritual “blueprint” of reality:
 - actions leave imprints in the higher/spiritual dimension of the world.
- Good deeds create עבירות; תיקון create קלקול (“repairs and breakages”).
- If one could “see” properly, the world itself would display the record of actions via their spiritual effects.

C. Connecting back to the three books of Rosh Hashanah

- Rabbi Shulman proposes:
 - the three books are three categories of recorded spiritual impact:
 - deeds of connection (life)
 - deeds of disconnection (death)
 - deeds that are “in-between” and await resolution

IV. What does “written for life/death” mean if everyone eventually dies? (19:00)

A. The classic question of the Rishonim

- If צדיקים are sealed for life, why do צדיקים die?
- If רשעים are sealed for death, why do long-lived רשעים exist?

B. Maharal in Chiddushei Aggadot: “life” is primarily spiritual connection

- Human beings are composite: גוף + נשמה; so too, reality is physical + spiritual.
- The Rosh Hashanah judgment is on whether one receives **connection to Hashem**, which Rabbi Shulman defines as **חיים**:
 - Hashem as **מקור החיים** (source of life).

C. Physical longevity depends on additional “variables”

- Even with a “decree of life,” a person may die due to:
 - physical deterioration (age, illness)
 - and **מזל** (a person's broader allotted life-trajectory)

- Rabbi Shulman's model:
 - Rosh Hashanah decides the "life-force/connection" input,
 - but bodily capacity + מזל affect whether that translates into continued physical life.

D. The inverse: why a רשע can live

- A רשע may be denied spiritual "life-force" yet continue on "battery life" (זלמ/physical factors).
 - But when his "armor" cracks, destructive forces can act quickly.
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V. Defining life and death as connection and disconnection to Hashem (24:30)

A. Identifying actions of "connection"

- Examples Rabbi Shulman elicits:
 - תפילה, תפילין, ברכות, שבת, and especially תלמוד תורה
- These deeds are naturally associated with לחיים because they are acts of דבקות/relationship.

B. Identifying actions of disconnection (עבירות)

- Examples:
 - לשון הרע, ביטול תורה, eating non-kosher
- These are written למיתה because in that moment they express rebellion/disconnection.

C. Chazal's language supports this definition

- Gemara Berachot:
 - "צדיקים אפילו במיתתן קרויים חיים" (the righteous are called alive even in death)
 - "ורשעים אפילו בחייהן קרויים מתים" (the wicked are called dead even in life)

D. Rabbi Shulman's rose analogy

- Cut rose in a vase: looks vibrant but is "dead" (no life source flowing in).
 - Rosebush trimmed down: looks unimpressive but is alive (still connected to life source).
 - Connection is the definition of life.
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VI. The “book of בינוניים”: the huge domain of mundane actions (30:01)

A. The practical challenge

- Most of a person's day is “neutral” activity:
 - sleeping, commuting, eating, working, daily routines.
- It seems impossible to have most actions be direct מצוות.

B. The Ramchal in Derech Hashem: mundane life is meant to be redeemable

- Rabbi Shulman explains (from Derech Hashem):
 - Hashem placed us among the mundane not to trap us in disconnection,
 - but to allow elevating ordinary acts through purpose and intention.

C. Three conditions to transform a “בינוני” act into a מצוה

1. **Permissible** act (not forbidden).
2. **Necessary/functional** for effective עבודת ה' (it genuinely supports serving Hashem).
3. **כוונה**: intention to do it for that purpose.

D. Clarifying boundary cases

- Not every enjoyable or optional act qualifies as “necessary” עבודת ה' facilitation.
- Without meeting the conditions, the action remains “בינוני”:
 - not an עבירה, but not a positive act of connection either.

VII. Why “not connecting” counts as “death,” and how it differs from עבירה (37:30)

A. The key conceptual move

- Rabbi Shulman argues:
 - If one is not connecting, one is (to some extent) disconnected.
 - in the sense of lacking “למיתה” can be categorized as כוונה a mundane act without לכן connection.

B. The distinction: “reconnectability” (Likkutei Amarim)

- Rabbi Shulman cites Likkutei Amarim:
 - The difference between “בינוני” and עבירה is not whether there is disconnection, but whether the act is **easily reclaimable**.
- is **אסור עבירה**—literally “tied up”:
 - trapped in negative forces; cannot simply be “raised” without full תשובה work.
- A permissible but mundane act can be elevated after the fact when one returns to Hashem’s service:
 - “עד אשר ישוב האדם ויחזור לעבודת ה’”
 - then the energy invested in those acts can “come along” upward.

C. Rabbi Shulman’s example: retroactive elevation

- Even if one ate permissibly without spiritual intent,
 - when one fully rededicates oneself, that energy becomes part of renewed עבודת ה’,
 - and thus can be reclassified “for life” in the book of בינוניים.
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VIII. The Gemara’s prooftexts: hints to three books and a lower-tier “with the righteous” life (42:30)

A. David HaMelech’s verse and the Gemara’s drash

- “ימחו מספר חיים ועם צדיקים אל יכתבו”
 - (Let them be erased from the book of life, and with the righteous let them not be written.)
- Gemara parses into three references:
 - “ימחו מספר” → book of רשעים
 - “חיים” → book of צדיקים
 - “ועם צדיקים אל יכתבו” → book of בינוניים

B. Moshe Rabbeinu’s plea after the Golden Calf

- “ואם־אין מחני נא מספרך אשר כתבת”
 - (And if not, erase me please from Your book that You have written.)
- Gemara’s parsing:
 - “מחני נא” → book of רשעים
 - “מספרך” → book of צדיקים
 - “אשר כתבת” → book of בינוניים

C. Rabbi Shulman's insight: the בינוני book is real and remains distinct

- The book of בינוניים does not disappear.
 - Those deeds remain “in that book,” but receive a “לחיים/למיתה” inscription.
 - Textual nuance supports a lower level:
 - “וְעִם צְדִיקִים” = not “the righteous,” but “together with” (a secondary tier).
 - “Your book” vs. “which You wrote” implies weaker attachment than the צדיק’s category.
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IX. Practical takeaway for Elul and Aseret Yemei Teshuvah: saving the “middle” deeds (46:31)

A. Two tracks of spiritual work

- עבירות: to remove/repair the tied-up damage
- בינוני deeds: massive opportunity—ensure they are written by return and rededication “לחיים”

B. How “זכו” happens for בינוניים

- Rabbi Shulman identifies “merit” as:
 - a full-hearted return to עבודת ה' with all one's כוחות—time, energy, abilities.
- Then the previously-neutral actions are “pulled along” into reconnection and recorded “for life” (though not on the same level as מצוות done intentionally).

C. Forward-looking goal for the coming year

- Increase the share of actions moved from “בינוני” into “צדיקים” territory:
 - by meeting the three Derech Hashem conditions regularly (permissible + necessary for avodat Hashem + כוונה).
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X. In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman explains that the “three books” on Rosh Hashanah (Rosh Hashanah 16b) are, per Rashi, **books of recorded deeds**—not simply lists of who will live or die.
- Following the Maharal, “life” means **connection to Hashem**, while “death” means **disconnection**, which resolves why צדיקים can die and רשעים can live physically.
- The “book of בינוניים” represents the enormous realm of mundane actions; these can become מצוות (permissible, necessary for) through three conditions (כוונה and ').

- Even past mundane actions can be reclaimed: through sincere rededication during עשרת ימי they can be written לחיים תשובה, in their own (lower-tier) category—"נעם צדיקים"—rather than remaining disconnected.